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Huge number of projects to be fast-tracked; some good, some bad

06 October 2024

"The Government has today announced 149 projects that will be listed in the Fast-track Approvals Bill," says Environmental Defence Society CEO Gary Taylor.

"Listed projects include public infrastructure, energy and housing developments which will help bridge New Zealand's infrastructure deficit and housing shortage. EDS is not opposed to fast-track processes for essential public infrastructure and housing.

"The Resource Management Act can be too slow and too expensive. However, the Fast-track Approvals Bill goes way beyond what is required to streamline processes.

"The list of questionable projects includes coal mines, open pit gold mines on conservation covenants, projects that have already been declined by independent decision-makers, major extensions to Auckland wharves and many more disasters for our natural environment.

"Coal mines are contrary to our international climate change commitments and free-trade agreements, and will lock us into fossil fuels when we should be transitioning away from them.

"Trans-Tasman Resources' seabed mining project is on the list, despite being rejected multiple times by independent decision-makers and putting potentially higher value industries like offshore wind, which need the same space, in jeopardy.

"A number of large-scale wind and solar project are included which is a good thing. Some of them occur on Significant Natural Areas, which pits climate change against biodiversity loss.

"Overall, we're blown away by the sheer volume of projects listed. We question how the Government intends to stand up enough qualified expert panels to process them in the timeframes indicated.

"As currently designed, the bill almost guarantees approval for the projects. It fails to properly balance development and environment considerations and instead has a deeply troubling bias in favour of applicants. That means that good projects will get approved along with the bad. Local communities will not have a say.

"The list will now be inserted into the Bill, via an Amendment Paper, without any opportunity for public input.

"In the next few days, the Government will release the report from the Fast-track Projects Advisory Group that triaged the hundreds of applications. That will likely give reasons for the Group's recommendations about what projects should be included in the Bill. We are still in the dark as to what criteria Cabinet ultimately used to decide what projects to list.

"The final and most important release will be the report to Parliament from the Environment Select Committee due on 18 October. That will reveal whether Government has listened to the public and agreed to include proper consideration of environmental and climate change matters and whether it will enable local communities to have a say.

"The proactive release of the list comes after EDS complained to the Ombudsman when its request for the names of projects under consideration was declined. People have a right to know what potentially life-changing development might be coming their way. It's outrageous that it's taken so long to find out and we thank the Ombudsman for his intervention.

"EDS will be carefully considering the implications of today's announcement and will be responding in due course. We will prioritise our attention on the most questionable projects," concluded Mr Taylor.

The list of projects is available [here](#).

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